

Developing a Digital Platform for Connecting Individuals with Reliable Faith Leaders.

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Research methods in IT

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Date: October 12th, 2025

DECLARATION

I declare that this research proposal is my original work and has not been presented in any other institution for academic purposes.

ABSTRACT

This research proposes the development of a digital platform aimed at connecting individuals with reliable and verified faith leaders. The study addresses challenges such as lack of credibility, privacy concerns, and unreliable access to spiritual guidance through existing platforms. The system is designed to ensure verification, trust, accessibility, and documentation while utilizing modern digital technologies. The proposal includes a literature review, system design objectives, feasibility assessment, and a work plan. The project aims to support ethical, secure, and user-centered spiritual interactions.

Table of Contents

Developing a Digital Platform for Connecting Individuals with Reliable Faith Leaders.	I
DECLARATION.....	II
ABSTRACT.....	III
DEFINITION OF KEY TERMS	VI
ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS.....	VI
CHAPTER ONE: RESEARCH OVERVIEW.....	1
1.0 Introduction	1
1.1 Background of the Study.....	1
1.2 Statement of the Problem.....	1
1.3 Objectives of the Study	1
1.4 Research Questions	1
1.5 Justification of the Study.....	2
1.6 Scope of the Study	2
1.7 Limitations of the Study.....	2
CHAPTER TWO: LITRATURE REVIEW	2
2.1 Introduction to literature.....	2
2.2 Theoretical review.....	2
2.2.1Need for faith leaders	2
2.2.2 Trust worthy faith leaders.....	3
2.2.3 Documenting the testimony of the faith leader services	3
2.2.4 Digital transformation of religion and faith leadership.....	3
2.2.5 Limitation of technology in relation to religion.....	4
2.2.6 Ethical concerns of technology in religion	4
2.3 Empirical review	4
2.3.1 Adoption and engagement with digital religious services	4
2.3.2 Use of websites	5
2.3.3 Use of mobile based application	5
2.2.4 Use of data protection tools	5
2.2.5 Adopting affordable services.....	5
2.3 Literature summary.....	5
CHAPTER THREE: WORKPLAN.....	6
3.1 Introduction	6
3.2 Feasibility Assessment.....	6

3.2.1 Technical Feasibility	6
3.2.2 Budget Feasibility	6
3.2.3 Schedule Feasibility.....	7
3.2.4 Conclusion	7
3.3 Project Justification	7
3.4 System Objectives.....	7
3.5 Functional Requirements.....	8
REFERENCES	10

DEFINITION OF KEY TERMS

Faith Leader: A religious or spiritual guide offering support and guidance.

Digital Platform: An online system enabling interaction between users.

Verification: The process of confirming authenticity of a faith leader.

Spiritual Guidance: Counseling offered based on religious or spiritual principles.

ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

ICT – Information and Communication Technology

UI – User Interface

UX – User Experience

TAM – Technology Acceptance Model

CHAPTER ONE: RESEARCH OVERVIEW

1.0 Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

In today's digital world, individuals increasingly turn to technology to fulfill their social, emotional, and spiritual needs. However, while digital solutions exist for education, healthcare, and commerce, the spiritual sector remains underdeveloped. According to Pew Research Center (2023), a considerable number of people participate in online religious activities, yet many still struggle to access credible and trustworthy faith-based guidance. Evolve (2021) notes that the rise of 'digital religion' has changed how people seek faith experiences and community engagement online. Similarly, Müller (2024) explains that digital media plays a vital role in religious communication, offering both opportunities and challenges in maintaining authenticity and connection. A study by ResearchGate (2024) also highlights that social media and online platforms have reshaped how faith messages are shared and received, emphasizing the need for regulation and trust. Despite these developments, there remains a lack of centralized, verified platforms connecting users to credible faith leaders. This study therefore aims to explore how a digital platform can be designed to improve access to reliable and authentic spiritual guidance.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Many people encounter challenges when trying to connect with spiritual guidance, some may opt to social media which is not that reliable or credible. This lack of structured access or networks to connect people with spiritual guidance calls out for digital technology to step in.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

These are the main objectives of the study:

1. To design a digital platform that connects users with verified faith leaders.
2. To examine the role of digital media in improving access to spiritual guidance services.
3. To analyze trust and credibility mechanisms in online faith-based platforms.

1.4 Research Questions

1. How can digital platforms improve access to verified faith leaders?
2. What challenges exist in seeking spiritual guidance online?

3. How can trust and reliability be ensured in online spiritual platforms?

1.5 Justification of the Study

This study is justified by the growing importance of digital transformation in all sectors, including religion. It will contribute to developing solutions that promote authenticity, accessibility, and accountability in faith-based services. The research also aims to remove the gap between spiritual care and technology, ensuring trust in digital spaces.

1.6 Scope of the Study

The research focuses on digital faith services, particularly how a platform can be developed to connect users with faith leaders. The study's scope is only focused on online-based interactions and user experiences.

1.7 Limitations of the Study

The following are problems likely to be encountered:

1. Digital illiteracy.
2. Diverse religion doctrines.

CHAPTER TWO: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction to literature

In this chapter, in deeper sense deals with reviewing the challenges people encountering when connecting with reliable faith leaders and the need for a digital platform that's trust worthy to eradicate the problem. During the study, this is reported in the follow up subheadings: Theoretical Review where a comprehensive discussion is made on the existing bodies of knowledge surrounding the research subject, the Empirical Review which discusses the solutions and how they are implemented and applied in real life and lastly, the Literature Summary

2.2 Theoretical review

2.2.1 Need for faith leaders

Faith leaders serve a crucial role when it comes to spiritual being of and individual, they offer spiritual support Cancellling and moral support. Contemporary literature establishes that the necessity of religious leadership stems from their unique capacity to influence both the internal morality of individuals and the external dynamics of the community (Rivis-Tipei, 2023). Beyond the spiritual realm, faith leaders function as primary ethical brokers within the broader public sphere, equipped to inject a necessary moral vision into policy debates and civic life, where issues are often perceived as purely technical or political (Bernardin, n.d.). During the covid 19 period these faith leaders acted various crucial roles in helping control the pandemic, these include sharing crucial information for safety and offering mental support. these is reported by world vision. Their influence is often understood through the lens of Servant Leadership, prioritizing the needs of the community

and inspiring followers toward higher moral commitment, often leading to transformational social change (StudySmarter, n.d.; PubMed Central, 2020). Beyond the spiritual realm, faith leaders function as primary ethical brokers within the broader public sphere, equipped to inject a necessary moral vision into policy debates and civic life, where issues are often perceived as purely technical or political (Bernardin, N.D.).

2.2.2 Trustworthy faith leaders

Finding a reputable faith leader is crucial when some ones need help. Trust is the bedrock of religious and spiritual authority; without it, the ability of a faith leader to offer guidance, counseling, and theological instruction is severely diminished (Kouzes & Posner, 2010). For a digital platform aiming to connect individuals with reliable leaders, the literature suggests that trustworthiness is built upon three pillars: Character and Integrity, Competence and Consistency, and Relational Transparency (Biblical Leadership, 2018). Trust in online interactions requires addressing the vulnerability a user accepts when revealing sensitive personal information (Baier, 1994; Friedman et al., 2025). Leaders can foster trust by. Embracing relational transparency (Walumbwa et al., 2008), which includes being appropriately vulnerable and communicating with clarity (Inside Sales Expert, 2023) For a digital platform, this is achieved by providing clear, verified information about the leader's credentials and professional history. Furthermore, the platform's design must support empathy, allowing the leader to listen to understand and demonstrate genuine care, thus translating traditional pastoral relationship qualities into a virtual setting.

2.2.3 Documenting the testimony of the faith leader services.

Documenting the services of faith leaders is crucial aspect in maintaining a trustworthy platform for connection. For a digital platform focused on reliability, the documentation process must be formalized to ensure accountability and trust. While a faith platform may not use clinical codes, it must adopt a defined minimum dataset to categorize the type, duration, and stated purpose of the service provided (e.g. pre-marital counseling, spiritual guidance, crisis intervention).documentation should be easily be accessed and read with minimal literacy documentation of the services should be scaled down to review and rating . The greatest challenge in documenting faith services is navigating the ethical landscape where the leader's service often involves deeply private and confidential disclosures. Documentation protocols must therefore explicitly prohibit the recording of client confidences or information that infringes upon the sacred trust (acrm, 2018). The literature strongly emphasizes that any documentation for administrative use or reporting must be de-identified to protect the client's privacy.

2.2.4 Digital transformation of religion and faith leadership

Mediatization of faith is a game-changing way to approach the need for a simpler, faster, and trustworthy way of connecting to faith leaders. The overarching theoretical framework for this transformation is the Mediatization of Religion (Lundby, 2011). This theory posits that media, including digital platforms, do not simply transmit religious messages neutrally; rather, they shape and mold the very structure, content, and experience of faith. Content Creator and Curator: Leaders must become adept at creating and curating engaging digital content, ranging from short-form video sermons to interactive spiritual Q&A sessions

(Campbell, 2012). Digital Shepherd: The leadership role extends to digital discipleship, requiring new methods for providing pastoral care, managing conflict, and maintaining ethical boundaries in online interactions, which often blur the lines between public and private life.

2.2.5 Limitation of technology in relation to religion

Although technology may seem like the final boss of most solutions it has its setbacks and limitations. Two of the major limitations that can be encountered are digital literacy and access to tech devices. Socioeconomic Barriers: Access to high-speed internet, reliable devices, and the skills to use them proficiently are not universal. This can exclude vulnerable or lower-income populations and older demographics from fully participating in online religious life or accessing digital faith leaders (Helland, 2005). Many people prefer physical contact for effectiveness which is not offered in digital interaction. Reduced Affective Engagement: Authentic religious life requires emotional and physical commitment (e.g., sharing a meal, laying on of hands, corporate worship). Screen-based interaction can foster a shallower, less affective form of engagement, turning faith into passive consumption rather than active participation (Lundby, 2011).

2.2.6 Ethical concerns of technology in religion

The integration of technology into religious life, while offering vast reach, introduces several significant ethical concerns that any digital platform connecting faith leaders must address. These issues center on privacy, manipulation, accountability, and the integrity of spiritual practice. misinformation and Fraud: Digital environments are fertile ground for unvetted individuals or groups promoting false doctrines, misinformation, or extremist views (Campbell, 2012). The platform has an ethical duty to prevent the use of its space for religious fraud or the radicalization of vulnerable users. Ethical guidelines must strictly govern how faith leaders solicit donations or fees through the platform. The design must prevent coercive practices that pressure individuals during moments of spiritual or personal distress. Digital interactions often lack the clear boundaries of a physical office or place of worship. Ethical protocols must establish clear rules for leader conduct regarding time boundaries, personal disclosure, and the initiation of contact outside of the platform (Waters, 2023).

2.3 Empirical review

This section reviews studies that have collected data on how and why individuals use digital tools for faith, focusing on established models.

2.3.1 Adoption and engagement with digital religious services

Empirical studies on the adoption and engagement of digital religious services often rely on frameworks like the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) to explain user behavior. Engagement rates are typically high for non-interactive content like sermons and scriptural readings, but empirical evidence suggests that users, particularly younger demographics, seek two-way interaction.

2.3.2 Use of websites

Websites historically represent the first wave of "religion-online" (Helland, 2005). Empirical data shows that organizational websites are primarily used for informational, archival, and administrative purposes. Usage patterns indicate high traffic for finding basic contact information, viewing organizational statements, and accessing past sermons or documents.

2.3.3 Use of mobile based application

Mobile Devices are widely used across the world making it most appropriate candidate to implement such a platform. The shift to mobile-based applications represents a move toward personalized, real-time, and ubiquitous religious engagement. Empirical data demonstrates that apps significantly increase frequency of engagement due to portability and push notifications, often integrating faith practices directly into daily routines (Campbell, 2012). Key findings show that successful faith-based apps prioritize:

2.2.4 Use of data protection tools

As users trust in a platform providing sensitive spiritual advice is directly tied to the perceived security of their personal data. Use of advanced data handling tools to prioritize confidentiality of the platform is crucial as seen in any platform in 21st century.

2.2.5 Adopting affordable services.

A Better way to get trust of the system is make sure more people can access it and trying to minimize the capital barrier. Minimizing cost of the system services will ensure that acceptance rate is high.

2.3 Literature summary

Our literature review gives a solid basis for the development of a digital platform that can link individuals with faith leaders who are sure and trustworthy. The research affirms that the world needs the platform, the technology is ready for it, and the stakes are high, thus requiring ethical rigor.

First, the context is provided by the Digital Transformation of Religion. We know faith has moved beyond simple websites and sermons (Religion-Online) to create entirely new virtual sacred spaces (Online-Religion). Although this is quite exciting, this shift challenged the traditional authority of spiritual leaders to establish credibility within the chaotic new digital environment (Campbell, 2012). The latter is exactly why it needs a platform that is verified.

The literature has identified the core ethical challenge that this platform would always face: the Digital Trust Deficit. Because spiritual consultations are personal and sensitive, the platform-in the absence of physical presence-must ensure leader integrity and competence through transparent accountability (Walumbwa et al., 2008). This calls for professional practices in the modification of documentation standards from clinical care, with strict protection of user data in maintaining sacred trust (acrrm, 2018). Ethical risks, such as

misinformation and data privacy concerns, are prerequisites that cannot be compromised on the road to success (Friedman et al., 2025).

Finally, it is the empirical evidence that confirms both the demand and the design path. Studies reveal that users are ready for digital religious services, driven by the clear benefit of finding help so easily. For this to work, the first design for constant access must be paramount, while the implementation of service models with affordable costs will mean that access to this lifeline is at least theoretically open to everyone, regardless of income level. World Vision International (2020) shows that this literature synthesis supports the need for a technically solid and ethically robust platform to bridge the current gap between user need and reliable spiritual leadership.

CHAPTER THREE: WORKPLAN

3.1 Introduction

This chapter outlines the workplan for developing the proposed digital platform that connects users with trustworthy and verified faith leaders. The following features are focused on feasibility assessment, project justification, system objectives, functional requirements, and the project schedule.

3.2 Feasibility Assessment

3.2.1 Technical Feasibility

The project is technically feasible because it requires basic hardware such as a computer or smartphone, and commonly available open-source software tools like HTML, CSS, JavaScript, MySQL, and development environments such as VS Code or XAMPP. The skills required—UI/UX design, programming, and database development—are achievable within the project timeline.

3.2.2 Budget Feasibility

The cost of the project is low since most required tools are free or open source. The only expected expenses include internet data, optional hosting/domain registration, and printing for documentation. This makes the project affordable for a student.

3.2.3 Schedule Feasibility

The project can be completed within the recommended **11-week timeframe**. Tasks such as design, development, testing, and documentation can be planned into weekly milestones, ensuring timely completion.

3.2.4 Conclusion

The proposed system is feasible in terms of technology, cost, time, and available alternatives. It can be developed successfully with the available resources and skills.

	Project alternative	Technical feasibility	Budget feasibility	Schedule Feasibility
	Use of physical consultancy and social media platforms	Computer devices such as phones are required	Low-cost project using free IDE tools	It can be completed within the 11-week academic period.
		Digital literacy	Server hosting fee of ksh 3000 per month	
	Not feasible		Purchasing domain name for ksh 4000	
Conclusion		feasible	feasible	feasible

3.3 Project Justification

The system is justified due to the increasing need for credible, verified, and accessible spiritual guidance. Current platforms do not guarantee trust or privacy.

3.4 System Objectives

3.4.1 General Objective

To develop a digital platform that connects users with verified faith leaders.

3.4.2 Specific Objectives:

1. Design a user-friendly platform.
2. Implement verification features.
3. Create secure communication channels.
4. Integrate documentation and rating features.

3.5 Functional Requirements

Participants: User, Faith Leader, Administrator.

Functional Requirements:

1. User account registration.
2. Faith leader verification.
3. Booking consultations.
4. Secure communication.
5. Documentation and rating features.
6. Admin monitoring and approval.

Participant	Role
Administrator	Monitoring the system and maintenance, Faith leader verification
User	Account registration, log in, Booking consultations, Documentation, and rating features
Faith leader	Offering spiritual guidance

3.6 Project Schedule Breakdown (Gantt Chart)

WEEKS	PROJECT MILESTONES			
	1	2	3	4
	Project Design & Modeling	Project Development & Testing	Project Deployment	Project Presentation
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
11				

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